Enabling nature-positive economies through enterprise partnerships: A Practical Guide

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This guidance is intended to support strategic partnerships that promote a nature-positive economy. The first part focuses on the 'scoping' or identifying stage of the partnership lifecycle, while the second part focuses on the 'building' and 'managing' stages. The guidance is intended for nature-positive enterprises (NPE) embarking on new partnerships. We hope it encourages NPEs to explore partnerships that support them in achieving their desired impacts and ambitions and contribute towards building nature positive economies.

Use this guide to consider:

- **Why you are partnering**
  See: Determining your Partnering Objectives
- **What potential partners are available**
  See: Identifying Partners
- **Whether specific potential partners are a good fit**
  See: Partnership fit test and SWOT Analysis Matrix
- **How to start the partnership relationship well**
  See: Partnership Workshop and Partnership Agreements
- **How to maintain a strong relationship over time**
  See: Managing Partnerships

Why partner?

What is a partnership and why do we want to partner? A simple definition of a partnership is ‘an intentional relationship to do something’. While you may have key relationships with various stakeholders, and you may do things with and for different economic and non-economic actors (e.g., government, civil society organisations, contractors, consumers, etc.), *partnerships* require both strong relationships as well as clarity and action for doing things together.

If chosen and managed well, partnerships can support NPE to drive impact at scale by enhancing growth and providing complementary skills and knowledge. A strategic partnership is one where the collaborative advantage of working together allows for impact that aligns with your objectives, and where that impact is greater than the partnership’s cost or risks.

Identifying and selecting the right partner, especially a private sector partner, is a critical decision. If a private sector actor aligned with NPE mission and values is present in the land/seascape and interested in partnering, they can provide access to valuable market insights, share costs in marketing, and provide many other benefits to accelerate NPE development.

Additionally, having multiple NPE partnerships within a land/seascape not only promotes each other’s success but also enables each partner to invest in conservation or restoration at a land/seascape level, which is critical for creating lasting change.

How to use this guidance

This guidance should be used by whomever you consider relevant in your organisation. For example, this could be one specific person or team, or someone with technical expertise in enterprises or partnerships.

These steps will require a mix of desk-based research, discussions within your network, and internal decision-making within your own organisation, and each step is likely to require an iterative process to complete.

> For example, one person might use their own knowledge and do internet searches to start filling in the ‘Identifying partners’ template. If they identify any gaps in their knowledge, they may reach out to their network and contacts to find out additional information. Then, they may schedule an internal discussion with decision-makers in the organisation to determine which partners listed are ‘yes’, ‘maybe’ or ‘no’.

Always adapt the template to your context! This template is intended to support your thinking, but you know best what your enterprise needs. Adapt the template as needed by adjusting the criteria, questions, or overall process.

Where should I start?

- Start by identifying your own objectives for partnering. Determine what you want to achieve through a partnership and what your NPE can offer to a potential partner.
- Use the objectives to shape your engagement with this guidance.
- For example, if you are looking for key technical skills, you will focus on looking for partners with those skills. Or, if you are looking for sales partnerships, you will focus on partnerships that may be interested in selling your products.
- If you are starting work in a new area or site, and you need to identify partners, we recommend starting with the 'Identifying Partners' template/section to explore which relevant actors are operating in the area.
  If you already know what potential partners are available, we recommend starting with Partnership Potential Analysis, Partnership Balance Matrix and SWOT Matrix Analysis to determine if available partners are a good fit for your work.
- If you have already decided who to partner with, start with Building partnerships: Partnership Workshop and Partnership Agreement.

Identifying Partners

Determining your Partnering Objectives

Before embarking on a partnership that will require time, energy and other resources, it is important to clarify why you want to partner.
partnering provides opportunities to access complementary ideas, knowledge, skills, services and products that are not immediately available to an organisation but are considered important to support its success. For example, for a NPE partners might add value on:

- *The enterprise side*: For example, knowledge or skills about how to generate revenues, who's your buyer, how to reach customers, or how to sustain the enterprise. Supply chain partners may be particularly helpful.

- *The nature-positive side*: For example, exchange of knowledge and skills to strengthen nature-positive impacts around shared objectives.

One way to determine your partnering objectives is to look at your business model or plan and consider:

- Where do you already have the skills, resources, knowledge and networks to achieve this plan?

- Where might you have gaps in skills, resources, knowledge or networks to achieve this plan?

- Would partnering fill any of these gaps? (Or would it be more appropriate to strengthen these internally?)

Try to write down clear, specific objectives for potential partnerships before you work through the steps in this guidance and use them as you make decisions about whether or not to partner and how to approach different partners.

As you complete the steps below, you may discover new ideas about ways you and your potential partners could benefit from each other. That's ok, too! You can adapt your objectives as needed.

Identifying Key Partners

This step will allow you to identify potential partners from different sectors, and if there are common linkages, opportunities, and challenges, which ultimately lead you to decide whether or not to further explore a partnership.

- If you would prefer to complete this step in Excel format, the corresponding template is available at the link provided here. *Tips:*

  Modify the template to fit your needs; for example, add additional sectors identified as needed.

  If you find it challenging to identify entities or businesses in these sectors, please consult your local chamber of commerce, banks, or government offices for lists of registered businesses.

Step 1: Identify potential partners across a broad array of sectors. (You can edit to the list below – add or remove sectors as needed.)

Agricultural and Forestry

- Timber products (e.g. Forestry management authorities (public or community-based)
- Non-timber products (e.g. Private forest owners' associations, Agroforestry enterprises and producer groups)
- Animal husbandry (e.g Pastoralist unions and cooperatives)
- Dairy (e.g. Milk collection and processing centres)
- Aquaculture (e.g. Fish farmers' cooperatives)
- Beekeeping (e.g. Honey cooperatives and producer groups)
- Nursery (e.g. Plant nurseries and seedling producers)
- Organic farming (e.g. Organic farmers' associations)

Tourism

- Hotels
- Guest houses
- Agrotourism Association
- Ecotourism company
- Tour operators
- Travel agencies

Local commerce

- Restaurants
- Food shops
- Souvenir shops

Government

- Local council
- Tourism promotion agency
- Agriculture promotion agency
- Innovation or start-up agency
- Chamber of commerce

Finance

- Banks
- Microfinance
- Grants including government funds
- Impact Investors

Support functions

- Transportation/ Logistics company
- Distribution/ Warehousing company
- Input providers (organic fertilizers, equipment providers)

Market creators or investment facilitators

- Certifications - Rainforest Alliance, B Corps, FairTrade, Global Sustainable Tourism Council
- Sustainability incubator

Other

- Private nature reserve
- National Park
- Other NGOs promoting businesses and technical support
- Universities / Business Schools

Step 2: For each potential partner, consider and note down your responses to the following prompts:

- Common linkages - How would a partnership align with each partners' objectives and interests? Where do you have geographic or thematic overlaps?

- Opportunities for collaboration – What could you do together?
- Challenges for collaboration – What are the potential risks, costs or issues associated with working with this partner?
- Profit distribution – how will the profits be shared?

Step 3: Make a decision about the partnership. For example:

- Yes – Good candidate for partnership, explore further;
- Maybe – Potential candidate for partnership, explore further but stop if not aligning;
- No – Not a candidate for partnership; no further exploration needed.

To make your decision about whether or not to explore the partnership, consider these questions:

- What value-add would partnering with this entity give us? What would be the collaborative advantage or impact of working together?
- Which partners address our objectives for partnering? Consider the common linkages here.
- Or, are there valuable new opportunities that we have not yet considered?
- Do the opportunities for collaboration outweigh the challenges for collaboration with this partner?

For partners that are a 'yes or a 'maybe', the next step is to consider more in more detail whether or not these potential partners are a good fit for your NPE's needs.

Partnership Potential Analysis

After identifying all the potential partners relevant to your objectives, it is important to intentionally decide whether or not a specific partnership is a priority for your work. There are many ways to determine partnership fit. Below is a series of discussion questions to consider for *each* potential partner. We recommend focusing on the partners assesses as 'yes' or 'maybe' in the Identifying Partners tool.

*If you prefer filling in this step in an Excel format, you can find the template linked here.

Step 1: For each potential partner, review the criteria in the questions below and note your responses; include details such as which specific additional customer segment or beneficiaries will be accessed. These notes will help you in the future

when you review whether or not the partnership is delivering the benefits you need.

- If you prefer to compare partners against each other or to report numerical values to decision-makers, the template provides an option for numerical scoring and comparison. Note that the scoring process takes significant time, so be clear to yourself about whether or not you really need it. For example: if you have two options for partnership but can only work with one of them.

You may add or edit these criteria based on your needs. (Examples of other types of value-add different types of partners might bring can be found here.)

The questions in the Partnership Potential Analysis section is a long and comprehensive list, and it may be more detail than you need for your decision. You may prefer to create your own, shorter criteria list, choosing key criteria from the menu of options below and/or drafting your own criteria.

Step 2: After reviewing all your potential partners, discuss and decide:

- Which partners offer the most benefit to us? And why?
- Do the benefits outweigh the potential costs or risks? (For example, reputational risks, loss of autonomy, conflicts of interest, or time required for alignment and engagement)

The final decision about whether partners are a good fit is going to be a subjective judgement call – you have to decide for yourself, based on your own needs!

For those partners that are determined to be a good fit for your enterprise, move on to the Partnership Potential Analysis.

Guidance for Completing the Partnership Potential Analysis template:

This scoring exercise helps you assess and compare potential partners based on both Impact (People & Planet) and Business Performance. The results show how well each partner aligns with your mission, values, and operational objectives, and position them in the Partnership Balance Matrix.

Impact (People & Planet)

Objectives

- Does the vision, mission, and values align?

- For example: Do they value nature, for example, by directly investing part of their profits to nature restoration projects? Do they have staff who are good communicators and team players? Do they have methodologies/approaches/networks that could enhance your impact?

- Would partnering with this entity support your partnership objectives? If so,

how?

- Does the partnership help bring better visibility and improve revenue for your nature positive enterprise?

Impact

- Will this partnership make a direct and measurable positive impact towards nature restoration?

For example: A nature-positive reforestation enterprise partners with a local conservation NGO. Together, they expand tree planting efforts, protect wildlife habitats, and improve ecosystem services in the landscape.

- Will this partnership make a direct and measurable positive impact for the local communities?

For example: An NPE producing herbal teas partners with a women's cooperative to source ingredients. The partnership creates 15 new jobs, increases household income by 30%, and provides training in sustainable harvesting techniques.

- Will this partnership make a direct and measurable positive impact for the economy of the landscape?

For example: A nature-positive enterprise partners with a regional tourism board and local producers to create a branded ecotourism route. This initiative boosts visitor numbers, increases sales of local products across multiple villages, and encourages investment in infrastructure — strengthening the overall economy of the landscape.

Business Performance

Customer & Market Benefits

- Will there be additional and strategic customer segments accessed through the partnership?

For example: A community-based eco-tourism company partners with local artisans → tourists can purchase handmade, sustainably sourced crafts, create additional income streams and support traditional practices that protect landscapes.

- Will this partnership allow the enterprise to gain additional market insights?

For example: A small organic farmer partners with a supermarket → they gain insight into consumer demand, seasonal buying patterns, and preferred packaging, which they couldn't easily access before.

- Will it be beneficial for customer relationships?

- Does the partner have a renowned 'good will' which people trust and are loyal

to the brand? This could give your NPE a competitive advantage by having a jump start in developing a strong brand with good customer relationships.

For example: A farmer cooperative partners with a conservation NGO → joint storytelling about positive landscape impacts boosts consumer engagement and brand loyalty.

- Will there be an opportunity to tap into a new channel to market and increase markets penetration?

For example: A nature-positive handicraft producer partners with an online marketplace, giving them access to e-commerce customers in addition to their local shop sales.

- Will the value proposition be strengthened?

For example: With upselling both products/services, the partnership can create a new experience for customers. An eco-tourism kayak company partners with a local wildlife photographer, offering customers the option to purchase professional photos from their tour as a package, creating a unique and memorable nature-based experience.

Operations

- Can some of the key resources be shared?

For example: Administrative costs, human resources, marketing costs, group purchasing agreements, industry consortiums etc.

- Can some of the key activities be delivered jointly?

For example: Using the same vehicle to transport their products/services, using the same production plant, selling products jointly, etc.

- Does this partner have the necessary skills and resources (like time) for delivering on the work we expect from them? Do we have the necessary skills and resources (like time) to deliver the work they might expect from us?

Finance

- Will the partnership help reduce costs or expenditure for the enterprise?

For example: The costs of producing the product/service, could lower with a group purchasing agreement. A honey producer partners with a local packaging company to bulk-purchase materials, reducing both production costs and actual spending.

- Will the revenue increase with partnership?

For example: More sales due to an increased sales force or better marketing campaigns. A nature-positive coffee cooperative partners with a specialty retailer, allowing them to sell to a new premium customer segment and increase overall revenue.

- Will the return on investment (if applicable) be achieved quicker with the partnership?

For example: A partnership may enable you to generate a larger revenue than initially projected. Under these circumstances, the NPE could potentially re-pay whoever invested in the NPE quicker than what was initially expected.

Governance

- Will there be clear rules in how the partnership is managed?

For example: A partnership could be established by a simple handshake, or it could be formalised through a contract or agreement with clear rules to operate by.

- Will there be a person designated to manage the partnership within each entity?

For example: Will there be one person accountable for the partnership in each entity? Will this person be hired for this specific role?

- Will there be a defined process for raising concerns and resolving conflicts?

For example: Two small businesses agree that any disputes over revenue sharing are first discussed in a structured call and, if unresolved, escalated to a neutral third-party advisor.

Step 1. Answer Each Question

You may find it helpful to use a scoring system to compare options for partnership. For each of the 17 criteria, select one option that best represents the partner's current situation:

Yes = 2 points
Partly = 1 point
No = 0 points

Be as objective as possible and use evidence (e.g., reports, discussions, due diligence) to support your scoring.

Alternatively, you may decide not to use score, but instead to qualitatively review how well partners align with your desired goals.

Step 2. Apply Weighting

Each question carries a different level of importance (weight) depending on how critical it is to achieving Nature-Positive Enterprise outcomes:

Category	Weight	Purpose
Impact & Objectives	3	Reflects strategic alignment with mission, vision, and environmental & socio-economic impact
Finance, Operations, Customer & Market Benefits, Governance	1-2	Reflects operational strength, market potential, and management capability

! Please note that the weight is automatically applied in the template.

Step 3. Calculate Weighted Scores

The Excel tool multiplies your response score (0–2) by the assigned weight (1–3) for each criterion. For example:
If you answered “Yes” (2) for a question weighted 3 → Weighted score = 2 × 3 = 6.

Step 4. Review Total Scores

The tool then sums all weighted scores to give two totals:
Impact & Objectives total (X-axis/horizontal) — max possible score: 24
Business Performance total (Y-axis/vertical) — max possible score: 36
The table converts both totals into percentages to allow comparison between partners.
These percentages represent the partner’s overall “potential” for collaboration.

Partnership Balance Matrix

The Partnership Balance Matrix is a strategic tool that enables Nature-Positive Enterprises (NPEs) to evaluate potential partnerships based on their alignment with impact goals (People & Planet) and business performance (financial and operational viability). By scoring and plotting partners across these dimensions, the matrix helps NPEs identify ideal collaborations, prioritise resource allocation, mitigate risks, and support balanced growth. It also fosters transparent, evidence-based decision-making with stakeholders, ensuring that partnerships contribute meaningfully to both ecological restoration and enterprise sustainability.

Step 5. Interpret the Results

After completing the scoring exercise, move on to the next section of the excel table, the Partnership Balance Matrix. Plot the percentages on the matrix:
X-axis: Impact (People & Planet)
Y-axis: Business Performance
Each partner will fall into one of four quadrants:

Business Performance	*High*	**Commercial Partners** Low strategic alignment & Impact; High operational & Financial viability	**Strategic Partners** High strategic alignment & Impact; High operational & Financial viability
	Low	**Emerging Partners** Low strategic alignment & Impact; Low operational & Financial viability	**Mission-Driven Partners** High strategic alignment & Impact; Low operational & Financial viability
		Low	*High*
		Impact (People & Planet)	

Step 6. Compare and Decide

Use the matrix and percentage scores to:

- Compare potential partners side by side
- Identify areas for improvement or capacity support
- Prioritise those with the strongest balance between impact and performance

The guide below gives details about opportunities each type of partner may bring. Use this to prioritise partners for engagement, based on your partnership objectives. Remember that partnership requires time!

Quadrant Interpretation Guide

Use the matrix to interpret where each potential partner falls based on their Impact (People & Planet) and Business Performance scores. The position indicates the partnership's overall strategic fit and the recommended next steps.

1. **Strategic Synergy Partners** (High Impact, High Business Performance)
Description: Ideal partnerships demonstrating strong mission alignment, operational strength, and financial viability. Prioritise these partners for collaboration, investment, and scaling.
Score Range: Impact ≥50%, Business Performance ≥50%
The opportunity with this type of partner is to deepen collaboration to maximise impact together. Effective for driving innovation too.

Strategic Opportunities:

* Co-design and co-implement and co-brand initiatives and projects
* Create high impact metrics to raise industry standards
* Collaborate on thought leadership, publications, and advocacy

* Expand proven models to new geographies or market channels. Channel funding, resources, and technical support
* Use the partnership as a hub to convene other actors. Facilitate peer learning and capacity sharing across the network

2. **Mission-Driven Partners** (High Impact, Low Business Performance)
Description: Partners with strong alignment to impact goals but limited business capacity. Valuable for reputation and long-term impact; may require targeted support, mentoring, or external funding to strengthen viability.
Score Range: Impact ≥50%, Business Performance <50%
The opportunity here is to become more sustainable in the long-term outcomes

Strategic Opportunities:

* Join up in multi-partner initiatives or multi-stakeholder forums where they can contribute impact expertise while others provide operational strength.
* Agree light-touch performance frameworks to incentivise progress without overburdening.
* Co-develop stories to demonstrate impact to donors, policymakers, and other stakeholders.

3. **Commercial Partners** (Low Impact, High Business Performance)
Description: Financially and operationally strong partners with limited alignment to nature-positive goals. Consider collaboration if financial returns or market access serve broader strategic objectives and explore ways to increase their impact contribution.
Score Range: Impact <50%, Business Performance ≥50%

The strategic opportunity here is to leverage commercial strength while nudging toward greater alignment with nature-positive goals:

* Use their reach to amplify nature-positive messaging or products. Co-brand initiatives that align with sustainability goals, even if indirectly (e.g., eco-labelling, sustainable sourcing). Pilot nature-positive products or services using their distribution channels.
* Offer technical support or co-investment in areas that could increase their impact (e.g., biodiversity-friendly practices, regenerative supply chains)
* Engage in co-designing initiatives that align commercial goals with environmental outcomes—e.g., circular economy models, green innovation labs. Frame nature-positive goals as risk mitigation (e.g., supply chain resilience, regulatory compliance, reputational benefits).
* Influence through data and evidence. Share business case studies showing how nature-positive practices have led to commercial gains. Use impact dashboards or scorecards to show where they stand and how small shifts could improve both impact and performance.
* Keep them on a watchlist for potential evolution into higher-impact partners. Set review milestones to assess whether impact alignment is improving over time.

4. **Emerging Partners** (Low Impact, Low Business Performance)
Description: Partners showing weak strategic alignment and low operational or financial viability. Generally, only recommended when justified by specific external

factors (e.g., policy, donor, or reputational considerations).
Score Range: Impact <50%, Business Performance <50%

The strategic opportunity here maintain visibility with key stakeholders and engage selectively; overall, to manage resources efficiently:
* Keep informed on key developments. Consult occasionally.
* Keep on a watchlist. they are being monitored for improvement or reassessment. There is potential for growth, even if current performance is low.
* Employ strategic caution while allowing for flexibility if external factors justify engagement
* Engage based on specific conditions and business case rationale
* Avoid long-term commitments and light touch engagement approaches (e.g., consultations, advisory, short-term pilots) if involvement is necessary.

SWOT Analysis Matrix

To help you set yourself up for a strong partnership, an analysis of the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats of creating a partnership with each potential partner should be evaluated.

> *If you prefer filling in this step in an Excel format, you can find the template linked here.

Ideally, this analysis is completed together with the partner, to enable shared understanding of each partner's strengths and weaknesses, and the opportunities or threats for working together.

In particular for the 'opportunities' and 'threats' sections, be specific about the external factors that may create opportunities for specific strengths or threaten existing weaknesses. Assess the partnership within its context:

Land(sea)scape: How might the physical land(sea)scape and nature that surrounds it affect the partnership? E.g. an endemic bird species, difficult access due to dirt roads, etc.

Business opportunities: How might the nature-positive business opportunities in your context affect the partnership. E.g. co-marketing with partner, lowering production costs by sharing the same production facility for products, etc.

Political environment: How might the political will for nature-positive businesses in the land(sea)scape affect the partnership? E.g. new government keen to develop a nature-positive business environment, a local 'ecotourism development plan' developed by the council, etc.

Legal/Policy: How might the current policy enabling nature-positive change to affect the partnership? E.g. tax incentives for nature-positive businesses, innovation hub for sustainable business models, etc.

Socio-economic: How might the support of local actors including landowners, community, and local businesses for nature-positive ambitions affect the partnership? E.g. landowners' willingness to engage in such activities, local market demand for nature-positive products and services, etc.

Tip: Adjust any questions and context considerations as appropriate to fit your needs.

Step 1: List the partners that you considered being a good 'fit' for partnership from the Determining Partnership Fit tool.

Step 2: Fill the matrix for each partner. (Either complete a separate matrix per partner or separate out any input that is relevant only to specific partners.)

Strengths What might the partnership be particularly good at? What strengths are each partner bringing that would benefit each other?	**Weaknesses** What might stop the partnership performing at its best? What gaps or weaknesses are there within each partner that might be barriers delivering the partnership objectives?
Opportunities What external factors in the environment could be specifically leveraged for benefits? Link to internal strengths. Where do you see the best upcoming opportunities for the partnership and its objectives? What is changing in the outside world that might create new opportunities for the partnership in the near future?	**Threats** What external factors in the environment could be particularly harmful? Link to internal weaknesses. What obstacles might the partnership face from the environment in which it operates? What high risk things are you doing that might make you vulnerable to external impacts?

An example of SWOT analyses of partnership between an organic cheese producer and retailer:

STRENGTHS Complementary Capabilities: The producer brings innovation and niche expertise; the retailer offers market access and customer reach. Brand Synergy: Retailers can enhance the visibility of NPE cheese through trusted platforms, while producers add unique value to the retailer's product mix. Shared Resources: Joint marketing, logistics, and data sharing can reduce costs and improve efficiency.	**WEAKNESSES** Market Education Required: NPE cheese may be unfamiliar, requiring significant consumer education and sampling efforts. Unequal Bargaining Power: Retailers may dominate negotiations, influencing pricing, shelf placement, and promotional priorities. Operational Misalignment: Differences in pace, priorities, or quality standards can lead to friction.

Consumer Trust: Retailers often have established customer loyalty, which can help introduce and validate new NPE products.	Limited Control: Producers may lose control over how their products are presented or marketed in-store.
OPPORTUNITIES Health & Sustainability Trends: Growing consumer interest in plant-based, functional, and sustainable foods aligns well with NPE cheese. Private Label Expansion: Retailers may want to co-develop exclusive NPE cheese lines, boosting volume and visibility. Cross-Promotion: Opportunities for bundling with complementary products (e.g., crackers, wine) or themed campaigns. New Market Segments: Retailers can help producers reach new demographics, such as flexitarians, vegans, or allergy-sensitive consumers.	**THREATS** Competitive Pressure: Other alternative cheese brands or traditional dairy producers may compete aggressively for shelf space. Consumer Scepticism: Novel ingredients or unfamiliar formats may face resistance or slow adoption. Regulatory Risks: Labelling, health claims, and food safety standards may vary across regions and require careful compliance. Retailer Strategy Shifts: Retailers may change priorities, discontinue products, or switch suppliers based on performance or trends.

Step 3: Decide what this analysis means for action. How will you build on the strengths? Address the weaknesses? Use the opportunities?
Mitigate threats? What feels critical? Where might you put your time and resources? What might be a short-term strategy, and what long term?

You may want to write down a list of actions

- You will take
- You would like the partner to take
- You will take together

After you have decided who to partner with, take time to build the partnership together with the partner – Building and Managing Partnerships

Building Partnerships

After determining which partnerships to pursue (see above, Identifying Partners), it is crucial that all partners understand:

- **Who each partner is.** What are the vision and values of each partner? What skills and resources do each partner bring?

- **Why they are working together.** What is the goal of the partnership? What is each partner's reason for being part of the partnership?

- **How they will work together.** What is each partner's role and responsibility? What is each partner agreeing to do, when and how? How will the partners stay in touch? How will decisions about issues of shared

interest be made? For how long will the partnership last, or how often will it be reviewed and changed?

The best way to learn about these issues is to talk about them together! You might start by having an informal, general conversation, to discuss who each partner is and what they want from the partnership.

Once it is agreed that both sides want to partner, we recommend having more in-depth discussions to establish a shared vision and clarity about how you will work together to achieve it. There are many ways to have these in-depth discussions. Below, we provide guidance on hosting a Partnership Workshop and creating a shared Partnership Agreement.

Partnership Workshop

The objective of this partnership workshop is to bring partners together to build a shared understanding of what the business opportunities and challenges of developing a nature-positive partnership are, and to develop an action plan for partnership development.

Step 1: Planning and preparing for the workshop

Time required for the workshop: Half a day to more than one day - depending on how far participants will be traveling from and the time availability. Where people are likely to arrive late, we suggest that the invitations propose an earlier start and/or a late lunch to be sure that there will still be four hours available for the workshop.

Note: if there is a need for a lot of translation for participants who are not familiar with the main language of the workshop, allow additional time.

Who participates?

- Participation in the workshop should be focused on the key partners identified; see above, Guide to Identifying Partners.

- For in-depth discussions where everyone gets to participate, we recommend keeping numbers low, not exceeding 10 people. Try to include a good balance of male and female representatives to enable an inclusive environment.

- If there are key stakeholders who could contribute to this discussion but who are not identified as good fit partners, decide what input you need from them and how best to get it – either by having them attend part of the workshop, or asking for input in other ways.

- It is always preferable to conduct the workshop in the local language. However, if there is significant ethnic or linguistic diversity among participants, translation should be arranged to ensure that everyone can fully understand the discussions and participate equally. If there are participants who do not

understand the workshop language, arrange for someone to sit next to them to quietly translate and allow adequate time for this. This is important, not only because people cannot participate if they do not understand, but also because failing to address their need for translation amounts to tokenism which, in effect, is denying that they are legitimate actors.

Preparation action: Invite participants in the appropriate way — for example, by letter, email or phone — at least one week before the meeting with a clear explanation of the costs you can reimburse (if any), such as allowances, travel costs or fuel, to avoid unrealistic expectations and bad feelings.

Who facilitates?

The NPE interested in partnering or an external body such as a consultant or NGO.

Preparation actions:

- Develop a workshop presentation including agenda of the day and different topics to be covered:
- SWOT analysis (optional)
- Develop vision, opportunities, challenges and action plan
- Next steps for partnership

Prepare all the equipment and materials necessary for the workshop. For example: Participant list, LCD projector and screen, flip chart papers and three marker pens, camera.

Step 2: Conducting the workshop

Opening:

- Welcome and open the workshop in accordance with local custom. Ask participants to introduce themselves and the organisation.
- Introducing the workshop: The convenor or facilitator should explain the objectives of the workshop and agenda of the day.
- Explaining the methodology: The convenor or facilitator should explain the steps that will be addressed in groups.

SWOT group exercise (*optional*):

- Go through the SWOT Matrix Analysis together to analyse the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats of creating a partnership in this specific context.

Vision, Opportunities, Challenges:

- Develop a shared vision for the partnership. Discuss how the Opportunities and Threats identified in the SWOT that relate this vision. (Or, if you do not do the SWOT together, discuss Opportunities and Challenges that will influence this vision).

Develop a joint Action Plan

- Develop a plan that clarifies who will do what, by when for the partnership to achieve its vision, and who will pay for this (consider time and money) to achieve the common vision.

- As a highly desirable, designate one person to monitor the completion of the action plan.

- Aim to have at least one partnership agreement to be signed in the action plan.

Next Steps:

- Discuss as a group by when the action plan will be delivered and when will the next group meeting will be. It is important to take advantage of the momentum generated through the workshop and set achievable dates and designate someone to follow up in order to establish a successful partnership.

- Be sure to identify who will follow up with any outputs from this Partnership Workshop (such as discussion notes or the agreed action plan).

Partnership Agreement

One tool useful for building a shared understanding for a strong partnership is a partnership agreement. Partnership agreements should be actively discussed before partners sign them, to make sure all partners understand each other and agree to what is written. Partnership agreements are not always legal documents, so the partners should also consider and decide together what type of agreement they need. For example, if they have legal obligations to each other, a contract may be more appropriate.

A partnership agreement might include:

- Goals and objectives of the partnership
- Implementation plan (if relevant)
- This plan should note whether resources for the work are already available, or what plans there are for mobilising resources
- Roles and responsibilities of each organisation
- Communication and decision-making structures. For example, how often will partners meet? Who is responsible for communication at each partner? How will decisions for the partnership be made? What is each partner's responsibility for sharing internal decisions that affect the partnership?
- When, why or how the partnership will end

More details on building a partnership are available from The Partnering Initiative's The Partnership Formation Journey and Partnering agreement template.

Managing partnerships

Strong partnerships require trust, transparency, mutual benefit and commitment to enable long-term, impactful shared work. It takes time and intention to manage a partnership well so that it can deliver on its goals. Trust is difficult to build and easy to lose!

To manage a partnership well, the partners should discuss and decide together on key structures and processes for the partnership during the partnership building stage. For example:

- How will decisions be made?
- You may want to use a structure to discuss decision making, like the RACI decision-making structure.
- What is the process for raising concerns or addressing conflicts?
- How often will partners discuss how well each partner is delivering on their roles, responsibilities and actions that they committed to each other?

In order to keep these agreements relevant and active, partners should also regularly discuss how well the original agreement is working and if anything needs to be changed.

Communication is often the most crucial tool for managing a partnership well. Partners should decide together on the best way to communicate including:

- Communication about what. (For example: What information will partners share with each other?)
- How often will they communicate?
- In what way will they communicate (For example: Face to face meetings, online meetings telephone, email)
- How to ensure communication and information sharing is effective. (For example: Are meetings focused, interesting and documented appropriately?)
- Who will do the communicating? This can be particularly important to consider in settings where who communicates can indicate respect, such as Directors talking with Directors.
- How those point people will share the information internally at their own organisation.

It can also be helpful to regularly review the partnership together. A partnership review may include discussion together about:

- How well is the partnership achieving its goals and objectives?
- What is helping the partnership achieve its goals and objectives?
- What is hindering the partnership from achieving its goals and objectives?
- How healthy is the partnership relationship?
- Do the partners understand and trust each other?
- What can be done to improve the partnership's impact?

More specific indicators of a strong partnership can be found in The Partnering Initiative's Partnership Healthcheck and The Partnership Relationship page.
For further inspiration on maintaining a constructive yet accountable relationship with private sector partners, see Oxfam's "Critical Friends" approach that provides a useful illustrative example among the broader range of resources available on this topic.